

THE MOVIE "U 571" IS SO INACCURATE THAT IT SPARKED AN OFFICIAL DEBATE IN THE BRITISH PARLIAMENT

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PART ONE

THE MOVIE VERSION



Imagine: it's 2000 and you're sitting on your couch, popcorn in hand, waiting for the newest American war production to appear on your screen. The film in question is *U-571*, starring Matthew McConaughey and showcasing daring heroes, underwater battles, and tension you could cut with a knife... But as you nestle into the narrative, something seems a bit off.

The tale unfurls: a group of American submariners embark on a secret mission to snatch the Enigma machine aboard a German U-boat during the tempestuous times of the Second World War. *It's thrilling, emotionally charged, and undeniably entertaining, but wasn't it the British who did that? You're right.*

The feat of seizing the Enigma, the device that enabled the Allies to decipher German naval codes, *was a British endeavor*, and this is where our story of celluloid and real-world parliaments entwines.



THE GERMAN ENIGMA MACHINE

OPERATION PRIMROSE

The actual seizing of Enigma machines by the British was a covert, dangerous operation that held the weight of the war within its grasp. The Royal Navy and its sailors demonstrated immense courage and strategic acumen in executing these operations.

The HMS Bulldog (H91), under the command of Capt. Joe Baker-Cresswell captured U-110 (not U-571) and its Enigma machine in 1941. This provided British codebreakers, including Alan Turing, with invaluable insight into German naval communications, which proved pivotal in turning the tide of the Second World War



HMS Bulldog (H91)



German Submarine U-110 and HMS Bulldog

The British efforts to decipher Enigma codes at Bletchley Park saved countless lives and accelerated the Allies' victory. The sailors faced incredible peril, with several losing their lives. The capture, dubbed *Operation Primrose, was top secret - even US President Franklin D. Roosevelt didn't learn about it until the next year from British Prime Minister Winston Churchill.*

THE MOVIE UPSET THE BRITISH PARLIAMENT



British House of Commons. - Getty Images)

The British Parliament, a venerable institution where discussions of state and strategy are held, found itself delving into the world of cinema when *U-571* was released. Members of Parliament (MPs), including veterans and those representing constituencies who had witnessed firsthand the impacts of U-boats, expressed their displeasure.

Prime Minister Tony Blair even commented that the production was an insult to the Royal Navy.

The overarching sentiment wasn't one of mere nationalistic pride, but of upholding the truth and honoring the fallen.

It was felt that the rewriting of history did a disservice to the real heroes of World War II, obscuring their sacrifices and bravery beneath a narrative that was palatably Hollywood but devastatingly inaccurate.

CINEMATIC LIBERTIES VERSUS HISTORICAL ACCURACY.



U-571, 2000. (Photo Credit: Carlito / Summit Entertainment)

Cinema often takes liberties with the truth, molding and shaping it into narratives that are compelling and commercially successful, but where should the line be drawn, especially when dealing with historical events and real-life sacrifices?

U-571 is a lens through which we can examine this delicate balance. Storytelling, especially when it intersects with real-life events and people, **bears a responsibility to honor and respect the truth.** It brings into focus the ethical considerations filmmakers must navigate when translating true events for the big screen, ensuring they honor the memories of those who lived them.

A moment of candid reflection came a few years after the film's release when screenwriter David Ayer acknowledged in an interview with BBC Radio 4's *The Film Programme* that *U-571* had bent the arcs of history. He shared a heartfelt admission about the discomfort he felt in implying it was Americans - not the British - who captured the naval Enigma cipher.

PUBLIC REACTION TO U-571



U-571, 2000. / Summit Entertainment / MovieStillsDB

While *U-571* was certainly a commercial success, raking in robust box office numbers, its reception was a mixed bag, globally. In the United States, audiences were enthralled by the adventure and drama, **likely largely unaware of the historical liberties taken by the script.**

In the United Kingdom and among WWII historians, however, the response was notably frosty, with the film seen as an affront to the actual heroes and a blatant rewriting of history.

IN CONCLUSION

In the echo of *U-571*'s fading credits, we find ourselves in poignant reflection. To honor the memories of the brave souls who truly ventured into the abyss during the darkest days of the Second World War, we must ensure their stories, unadulterated and true, continue to echo through history.



Director and co-screenwriter of *U-571* (2000), Jonathan Mostow. (Photo Credit: Getty Images)

This debate serves as a timeless reminder of the weight that stories carry and the imperative to tell them with respect, honor, and truth, especially when they're intertwined with the experiences of real-life people. It beckons filmmakers and storytellers to tread thoughtfully when navigating the sacred ground of history, ensuring the legacies of true heroes remain undimmed.

PART TWO

THE REST OF THE STORY – WHAT REALLY HAPPENED

German submarine *U-110* was a Type IXB U-boat of Nazi Germany's *Kriegsmarine* that operated during World War II. She was captured by the Royal Navy on 9 May 1941 and provided several secret cipher documents to the British

The boat was part of the 2nd U-boat Flotilla from her commissioning date until her loss. Lemp commanded *U-110* for her entire career. In an earlier boat (*U-30*), he was responsible for the sinking of the passenger liner *SS Athenia* on the first day of the war. The circumstances were such that he was considered for court-martial. He continued, however, to be one of the most successful and rebellious commanders of his day.^[2] The boat departed Lorient on 15 April 1941. On the 27th, she sank *Henri Mory* about 330 nautical miles (610 km; 380 mi) west-northwest of Blasket Islands, Ireland.

Her next quarry was the ships of convoy OB 318 east of Cape Farewell (Greenland). She successfully attacked and sank *Esmond* and *Bengore Head*, but the escort vessels responded. The British Corvette, *HMS Aubrietia*, located the U-boat with ASDIC (sonar). *Aubrietia* and British destroyer *Broadway* then proceeded to drop depth charges, forcing *U-110* to surface.

U-110 survived the attack but was seriously damaged. [HMS Bulldog](#) and *Broadway* remained in contact after *Aubrietia*'s last attack. *Broadway* shaped course to ram, but fired two depth charges beneath the U-boat instead, in an endeavour to make the crew abandon ship before scuttling her. Lemp announced "Last stop, everybody out", meaning "Abandon ship". As the crew turned out onto the U-boat's deck they came under fire from *Bulldog* and *Broadway* with casualties from gunfire and drowning. The British believed that the German deck gun was to be used and ceased fire when they realized that the U-boat was being abandoned and the crew wanted to surrender.

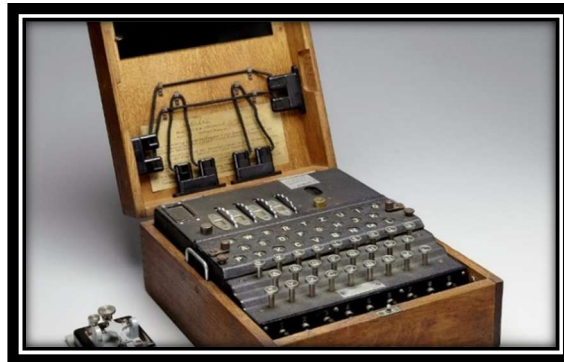
Lemp realized that *U-110* was not sinking and attempted to swim back to it to destroy the secret material, but was never seen again. A German eyewitness testified that he was shot in the water by a British sailor, but his fate is not confirmed. Including Lemp, 15 men were killed in the action, and 32 were captured. Radio Officer Georg Högel and the rest of the crew were held at *Camp 23* (Monteith POW camp at Iroquois Falls, Northern Ontario, Canada), which is now the Monteith Correctional Complex.

Bulldog's boarding party, led by Sub-Lieutenant David Balme, got onto *U-110* and stripped it of everything portable, including her Kurzsignale code book and Enigma machine.

William Stewart Pollock, a former radio operator in the Royal Navy and on loan to *Bulldog*, was on the second boat to board *U-110*. He retrieved the Enigma machine and books as they looked out of place in the radio room. *U-110* was taken in tow back toward Britain but sank en route to Iceland. The documents captured from *U-110* helped Bletchley Park codebreakers solve *Reservehandverfahren*, a reserve German hand cipher.

PART THREE

ENIGMA MACHINE SELLS FOR A RECORD \$ 463,500



One of the rarest surviving Enigma cipher machines has sold at auction for a record price of US\$463,500. An artifact of one of the most exciting episodes of World War II, the fully operational Enigma M4 was made in 1943 for Admiral Doneitz's Kriegsmarine to send secret messages to the German U-boat packs at the height of the war. It was part of the Bonhams History of Science and Technology Sale in New York City and easily surpassed the previous record of US\$350,000 set in 2015.

According to Bonhams, only 120 out of 1,600 Enigma M4 machines still exist, with most of them in government storehouses. The M4 Naval Enigma was developed in 1941 after Doenitz rightly suspected that the previous M3 machine was compromised by Allied codebreakers.

The Enigma used a complicated series of electromechanical circuits running through banks of four removable rotors and plugs that could be programmed to produce 153 trillion unique sequences to foil decryption experts.

The Germans used the M4 exclusively to send communications between the German Naval High Command and the U-boat wolf packs attacking Allied shipping. The Nazi High Command believed the Enigma to be a highly secure means of communication, but British decryption teams, which included computer pioneers, Alan Turing and Tommy Flowers, used some of the earliest and most advanced computers to break the Enigma codes and read some of the German's most secret messages, giving the Allies a significant advantage over the Nazis. From its fine condition, Bonhams says the Enigma M4 sold was probably used by a shore base rather than on a submarine. It was purchased from a family in Norway and is one of the few not lost at sea or destroyed by retreating German forces at the end of the war in 1945.

"This M4 Enigma was in perfect condition and very desirable," says Bonhams Science and Technology specialist Tom Lamb. "Most of the 120 or so M4 Enigma machines known to have survived are in museums or government hands so this was a rare chance to acquire one of the very few still available. I am, of course, delighted to have broken our world record."

DISCLAIMER

PLEASE UNDERSTAND THAT EVEN THOUGH THIS INFORMATION HAS BEEN TAKEN FROM WEBSITES & OTHER SOURCES THAT APPEAR TO BE AUTHENTIC, I CAN NOT ENSURE THAT ALL THE DATA IN THIS ARTICLE IS ACCURATE AND CORRECT.